disliked him. The reason for this, in the text, has to do with Ashoka's unattractive appearance—his skin was rough and unpleasant to the touch. However, his mother advised Ashoka not to resist being examined. Eventually, when he, along with various other princes, was subjected to the sage's gaze, it became evident to the Ajivika that Ashoka must succeed Bindusara. Yet although Pingalavatsajiva realized this, he thought it prudent not to pronounce his choice immediately, for he knew the ruler-father did not like Ashoka. So, without mentioning his name to Bindusara, he made the prediction that the 'one who had the best mount, seat, drink, vessel and food' would become the emperor. Ashoka later told his mother: 'The back of an elephant was my mount, the earth was my seat, my vessel was made of clay, boiled rice with curds was my food, and water was my drink; therefore, I know I shall be king.'[30] In much the same way that Jaya's persona had earlier passed the Buddha's scrutiny and been recognized as destined for future greatness, the suitability of the now-adult prince as Bindusara's heir is linked in the story with his personal qualities. Pingalavatsajiva is said to have met Ashoka's mother and told her that Ashoka would succeed Bindusara. Upon her advice the Ajivika left the kingdom lest he be forced by the king to give an answer which might endanger him. When Bindusara died, Pingalavatsajiva, it is said, returned to Magadha.

It was normal for a queen who had been made aware of her son's destiny, but whose progeny did not include the eldest male child of her husband, to have kept the knowledge to herself. In large polygamous royal households there were other queens who harboured similar 'kingly' ambitions for their sons: everyone familiar with the Valmiki *Ramayana* will recall the several wives of Dasharatha, king of Ayodhya, one of whom, Kekayi, machinates for her own sons against those of her co-wives and thereby sets the whole epic in motion. In terms of the present narrative, the queen keeping matters secret was also necessary because Bindusara's eldest